

The Star CASTE

Chiranjeevi rides high on popularity and caste calculus in a bid to be the state's second chief minister from tinsel town

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

He has done it so many times on screen that Chiranjeevi, who is famous enough to be known only by his first name, doesn't need a director's cue any more. At first he stands, hands on hips, then raises both arms with a swish, flashing both thumbs up and a wide grin. The audience roars in approval as Telugu cinema's popular megastar appears in a political avatar.

In the sectarian and caste-inspired politics of Andhra Pradesh, Chiranjeevi has arrived to alter the paradigm. His Kapu community accounts for about 15 per cent of the state's population and is concentrated in the coastal districts. Though not listed among the backward classes, Kapus are reckoned among politically disadvantaged groups. But in rousing them and the 109 listed backward classes that account for 37.1 per cent of the state's 7.62 crore population, Chiranjeevi is fast becoming the trademark of hope and optimism.

On August 26 last year, he launched the state's newest political party, the Praja Rajyam Party (PRP), in the temple town of Tirupathi, from where he will contest for the 294-seat state Legislative Assembly. Since then, Chiranjeevi has criss-crossed 23 districts of the fourth-largest state in the

country, nursing ambitions of being the next chief minister. When polling is completed in two phases, April 16 and 23, he hopes to achieve in just eight months what took another thespian-turned-politician N.T. Rama Rao (NTR) nine months after founding the TDP to become the first non-Congress chief minister in 1983. All comparisons, however, end here.

Chiranjeevi is up against formidable odds. While on one hand, there's

the Congress with the incumbent Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy (YSR as he is widely known), a strongman who has had an uninterrupted five-year reign, on the other hand is the TDP steered by N. Chandrababu Naidu, the longest-serving chief minister of the state who has now formed a Grand Alliance with YSR's 2004 poll allies—the Telangana Rashtra Samithi, CPI and CPI(M).

Poor governance and unbridled



CHIRANJEEVI
AT A CAMPAIGN
RALLY

ANDHRA'S TRADITIONAL TWO-PARTY POLITICS IS IN DANGER OF BEING OVERTURNED BY A MAN WHO ACCUSES BOTH HIS RIVALS, YSR AND NAIDU, OF CONSPIRING AGAINST HIS PARTY TO PREVENT A BACKWARD CLASS LEADER FROM BECOMING CM.